

Divine Purpose in Human Suffering:

Theodicy and Moral Formation in Job and Mencius

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Abstract

This essay reads the book of Job alongside *Mengzi* 6B15 (the fifteenth section of "Gaozi II") through cross-textual hermeneutics, arguing that the two texts generate not a synthesis but a productive tension over the role of suffering in moral formation. Although a mature literature now treats the problem of evil within classical Chinese philosophy, and comparative theology has refined its cross-textual methods, no sustained reading has yet set Job beside the *Mengzi* on the question of how suffering forms character. This essay attempts that reading in three moves: it adopts Archie Lee's cross-textual method, which lets each text argue in its own idiom; it takes *Mengzi* 6B15, a passage far more explicit than the *Analects* about the pedagogy of adversity, as the Confucian anchor; and it makes Job 23:10 ("when he has tested me, I shall come out like gold," כִּי בִּחְנוּנֵי כֶּהָב יֵצֵא אֲנִי) the hinge of the argument. Read with Mencian eyes, Job's metallurgical image betrays a teleological instinct that the dominant Western philosophical frames—Stoic endurance, Platonic ascent, Leibnizian optimism—are not well equipped to describe. The structural parallel between *tummâ* (תִּמְמָה, integrity) and *duan* (端, the moral "sprouts"), both qualities that suffering refines rather than creates, is the essay's central contribution. Job restrains the Mencian drift toward over-systematization; *Mengzi* keeps the Joban narrative from collapsing into nihilism.

Keywords: Job – Mencius (*Mengzi*) – theodicy – cross-textual hermeneutics – moral formation – suffering – *tummâ* – *duan* – productive tension – comparative scripture

1. Introduction

Few questions press on the religious traditions of the world more persistently than the relation between suffering and the formation of moral character. The last several decades have opened

real space for cross-traditional conversation in comparative theology and philosophy, yet substantive dialogue between the Hebrew wisdom literature and early Confucian thought remains thin, and thinnest of all on the question of theodicy. Western scholarship has examined Job's indictment of retributive justice exhaustively; what it has rarely done is set that indictment beside a tradition that thematizes adversity as the ordinary medium of moral growth. This essay attempts precisely that juxtaposition.

Two bodies of scholarship bear directly on this project, yet they have not been brought into contact. On one side, a mature literature now examines the problem of evil and the moral operation of Heaven within classical Chinese philosophy itself, showing that early Confucian thought commands its own sophisticated resources for thinking about undeserved hardship.¹ On the other, comparative theology and cross-textual hermeneutics have matured into disciplined methods for reading scriptures across traditions without dissolving one into another. What neither body of work has yet attempted is a sustained encounter between the book of Job and the *Mengzi* on the precise question that animates this essay—not whether suffering is just, but *how*, concretely, suffering forms moral character. That is the gap this essay sets out to fill.

The inquiry proceeds in three deliberate moves. First, I adopt Archie C. C. Lee's cross-textual hermeneutics, which permits the two texts to converse within their own logics and so avoids both syncretism and false equivalence.² Second, I take *Mengzi* 6B15 as the Confucian anchor, since it addresses adversity as a deliberate, purposive process of moral cultivation with a

¹ On the problem of evil and the moral operation of Heaven in classical Chinese thought, see Franklin Perkins, *Heaven and Earth Are Not Humane: The Problem of Evil in Classical Chinese Philosophy* (Bloomington: Indiana University Press, 2014); and Youngsun Back, "Confucian Heaven (天 *Tian*): Moral Economy and Contingency," *European Journal for Philosophy of Religion* 8, no. 1 (2016): 51–77. On the vulnerability of moral integrity to circumstance in early Confucian thought, see Michael D. K. Ing, *The Vulnerability of Integrity in Early Confucian Thought* (New York: Oxford University Press, 2017). None of these studies sets the Confucian material beside the book of Job.

² Archie C. C. Lee, "Cross-Textual Hermeneutics and Identity in Multi-Scriptural Asia," in *Christian Theology in Asia*, ed. Sebastian C. H. Kim (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2008), 179–204. I follow Lee's insistence that juxtaposition, not synthesis, is the hermeneutical engine of cross-textual reading.

directness the *Analects* never musters. Third, I make Job 23:10 the demonstration text, and argue that when it is read with Mencian eyes a teleological instinct surfaces in it—an instinct that the Stoic, Platonic, and Leibnizian frames through which the verse has most often been read are, in their several ways, ill-equipped to describe, and so tend to leave under-articulated.

The thesis is this. The metallurgical image of Job 23:10—"when he has tested me, I shall come out like gold" (כִּי בִּחְנֹנִי כֶזֶבֶב אֵצֶל)—discloses, within a Mencian frame, an intuition about the purposiveness of suffering. That intuition stays open in Job, held in suspension by the opacity of the theophany; but it is structurally of a piece with Mengzi's conviction that Heaven (*tian* 天) refines moral character through hardship. The two concepts that carry the comparison—*tummâ* (תְּמָה), the integrity that suffering tests, and *duan* (端), the moral sprouts that adversity matures—share a single deep grammar: in both traditions suffering is a refiner of what is already latent, not a fabricator of something new.

Three gaps in the current literature frame the inquiry. The first is the still-undeveloped conversation between ancient Near Eastern wisdom and Warring States Chinese philosophy. The second is the lack of sustained contact between Joban theodicy and Confucian frameworks of self-cultivation. The third is the limited traffic between biblical studies and non-Abrahamic scriptural traditions in a genuinely cross-textual mode. By staging a specific encounter between Job and Mengzi on the single question of how suffering forms—rather than merely punishes—I hope to make a small contribution toward closing all three.

2. Methodological Framework

Archie Lee's cross-textual hermeneutics supplies the method. Forged in the multi-scriptural setting of Asian Christianity, its governing intuition is that the juxtaposition of distinct scriptural

traditions can throw off interpretive light that belongs to neither tradition alone and that requires no prior assumption of metaphysical commensurability between them. The procedure has three moments: one establishes a common question—the *tertium comparationis*—that both traditions can be heard to ask; one then reads each text closely within its own frame, refusing to project the categories of one onto the other; and one allows the mutual illumination to emerge in juxtaposition rather than synthesis. The method differs from simple analogy in that it does not presume the two traditions will arrive at the same answer. Difference and dialogue are allowed to coexist. The method aspires to mutual illumination rather than mere adjacency: the juxtaposition must yield something a reader of either text alone would miss, or it has failed.³ The claim of a productive tension is not, for that reason, immune to disconfirmation. Were the two texts to prove, on close reading, to give the same account of suffering, the tension would collapse into redundancy; were their difference to turn out merely terminological, it would collapse into syncretism. The reading earns its claim only if substantive, non-reducible divergence survives scrutiny—which is what sections 6 and 7 are meant to test.

The common question of this study is: how does a divine or cosmic power act in human suffering so as to form moral character? It stands at the center of both the book of Job and *Mengzi* 6B15, and the two traditions answer it in markedly different registers. That difference is a methodological asset, not an obstacle. It is precisely through their divergence that the distinctiveness of each tradition comes into relief, instead of being flattened into a syncretistic average.

One objection must be met before the comparison can proceed at all. Franklin Perkins has argued that classical Chinese philosophy does not, on the whole, pose suffering as a "problem of

³ On comparative theology as "deep learning across religious borders" rather than the mere juxtaposition of traditions, see Francis X. Clooney, *Comparative Theology: Deep Learning Across Religious Borders* (Malden, MA: Wiley-Blackwell, 2010), esp. chap. 1.

evil" in the sense the monotheistic traditions know, precisely because its Heaven is not a benevolent and omnipotent person whose goodness must be vindicated; where there is no such agent to exonerate, there is no theodicy in the strict sense to build.⁴ One might therefore worry that setting Job beside the *Mengzi* commits a category mistake—measuring a tradition that has no problem of evil against one that is consumed by it. The objection sets the terms of the comparison rather than blocking it. The *tertium comparationis* of this essay is deliberately not the justification of God but the narrower, genuinely shared question of suffering's formative function: how a cosmic power, however it is conceived, acts in adversity to form moral character. Pitched there, the comparison does not require that the *Mengzi* possess a problem of evil, only that it offer an account of what suffering does to the person who undergoes it—which 6B15 conspicuously supplies. Indeed the very contrast Perkins draws becomes one of this study's data rather than an obstacle to it: that Job must defend a personal God while Mengzi need not is exactly the kind of non-reducible divergence the cross-textual method is built to preserve.

A word on metaphysics is needed at the outset, since it governs everything that follows. I read the *tian* (天) of the *Mengzi* as a cosmic power that is *functionally intentional* rather than *metaphysically personal*—its operation displays purpose without thereby presupposing a personal will of the kind one petitions.⁵ This sets it in instructive contrast with the YHWH of Job, a personal deity who can be addressed, argued with, and called to account in the idiom of the lawcourt. The distinction lets the two traditions speak to the same question—the function of suffering within a cosmic order—without forcing either to assimilate to the other. Job's suffering

⁴ Perkins, *Heaven and Earth Are Not Humane*, argues that classical Chinese philosophy largely does not frame undeserved suffering as a "problem of evil" in the monotheistic sense, since its Heaven is not a benevolent, omnipotent person whose goodness stands in need of defense. I take the point to set the terms of the present comparison rather than to block it: the *tertium comparationis* here is the formative function of suffering, not the justification of God.

⁵ Kwong-loi Shun, *Mencius and Early Chinese Thought* (Stanford: Stanford University Press, 1997), 58–79, on the semantic range of *tian* and its non-anthropomorphic operation.

is defined within a rupture of relationship; the suffering Mengzi describes is a functional context of development, not the breaking of a bond.

I take a methodological caution from Kenneth Surin. Any attempt to systematize theodicy into a tidy theory, Surin warns, risks reducing real suffering to a conceptual game and so betraying the sufferer.⁶ I accept the warning. The aim here is not to offer a synthetic theory that solves the problem of evil, but to hold two traditions in tension through juxtaposition—to keep, in other words, a productive tension rather than to engineer a facile resolution.

The justification for reading the Hebrew Bible cross-culturally is straightforward. The Hebrew scriptures did not arise in a vacuum; they belong to the wider wisdom culture of the ancient Near East, within which the suffering of the righteous was already being turned over—most notably in the Mesopotamian compositions *Ludlul bēl nēmeqi* and the so-called *Babylonian Theodicy*, the standard comparative analogues to Job.⁷ That Job invites comparison with other wisdom traditions is, then, hardly a novel proposal; the comparison with this Mesopotamian material is well worn. The novelty claimed here is correspondingly narrow and specific: not that Job may be read comparatively, but that it may be read beside the *Mengzi* on the single question of how suffering forms moral character. The East Asian classics participate, for their part, in moral inquiry that crosses cultural boundaries. To bring Confucian thought to bear on biblical interpretation is not to swap one imported framework for another but to expose dimensions that the inherited frames are apt to leave under-described—here, the teleological instinct in Job, which the frames of Stoic fortitude, Platonic purification, and the Leibnizian calculus of the best possible world are not well suited to articulate.

⁶ Kenneth Surin, *Theology and the Problem of Evil* (Oxford: Blackwell, 1986), 1–59. Surin’s warning against “theoretical” theodicies that dissolve concrete suffering into abstraction informs the argument throughout.

⁷ The Mesopotamian “righteous sufferer” compositions—*Ludlul bēl nēmeqi* (“I Will Praise the Lord of Wisdom”) and the so-called *Babylonian Theodicy*—are the standard ancient Near Eastern analogues to Job; both are edited in W. G. Lambert, *Babylonian Wisdom Literature* (Oxford: Clarendon Press, 1960). The comparison of Job with this material is well established; what is novel here is rather the juxtaposition with the *Mengzi*.

3. Job's Integrity and the Theological Weight of Suffering

3.1 *Tummâ*: A Theology of Integrity

The theological center of Job is not an intellectual answer to the question of why suffering exists but a dramatic probing of an existential one: whether integrity (*tummâ*, תִּמְמָא) can survive in suffering at all. The word does real work in the frame narrative, for it is Job's integrity that YHWH himself invokes as the ground on which the test is permitted: Job "still persists in his integrity," even after the adversary has incited God against him "to destroy him for no reason" (2:3). Habel notes that *tummâ* denotes not mere moral compliance but a wholeness of character—an organic integration of inner disposition, outward act, and relation to God that cannot be reduced to rule-keeping.⁸ The point matters because it fixes what suffering is for. Integrity is the thing that suffering tests, and the thing that suffering refines; it is not the thing that suffering confers. *Tummâ* is already present in Job before the calamity—he is "blameless and upright, one who feared God and turned away from evil" (1:1)—and the function of his ordeal is to test whether that prior character can hold, and show itself genuine, under extreme pressure.

Job's integrity comes into still sharper focus in the way he addresses God. He stands on the ground of being "blameless" (*tām*, תָּמִי) and "upright" (*yāšār*, יָשָׁר), as 1:1 has it, and from that ground mounts his protest against the justice of God. His protest is better read as the failure of a complacent piety than as the failure of faith: it is, under assault, the very holding-fast of integrity. His refusal to make a false confession—to purchase relief with a lie about himself—is *tummâ* (תִּמְמָא) in its most severe form.

3.2 The Three Friends and Their Theologies

⁸ Norman C. Habel, *The Book of Job: A Commentary*, OTL (Philadelphia: Westminster, 1985), 540–41.

Job's three friends voice three variants of an orthodox retributive theology. Each grounds its reading of his suffering in a different source of authority, but all three finally serve the same mistaken logic.

Eliphaz appeals to personal experience and vision. He claims a nocturnal revelation (4:12–16), and from that visionary experience derives the axiom that no mortal can be righteous before God—"Can mortals be righteous before God? Can human beings be pure before their Maker?" (4:17)—and so infers that Job's suffering must answer to some hidden fault (22:4–5). His argument carries a certain theological finesse; he does not simply accuse, but invokes a universal human frailty. Yet his conclusion still obeys the retributive grammar: repentance will restore.

Bildad rests his authority on ancestral tradition. He invokes the accumulated wisdom of the forebears—"inquire now of bygone generations, and consider what their ancestors have found" (8:8)—and treats the moral order of the cosmos as a historically validated certainty. His theology is conservative, and its logic is simple and forceful: tradition has already demonstrated the correspondence of suffering and guilt; therefore Job's suffering must point to some wrong he has not yet owned.

Zophar represents dogmatism in its purest form. The bluntest of the three, he insists that God in fact exacts of Job less than his guilt deserves (11:6). His theology passes through no softening and no qualification: the law of retribution is absolute, and the only account of any apparent deviation is sin. The friends err not in believing that a moral order exists—Job believes that too—but in reducing that order to a mechanically applicable causality, and so screening off the transcendence and mystery of the divine reality. God condemns them explicitly in the epilogue: they have "not spoken of me what is right, as my servant Job has" (42:7).

3.3 Job 23:10: Metallurgy and the Teleological Instinct

Job 23:10 is the pivot of this study:

"But he knows the way that I take; when he has tested me, I shall come out like gold." (Job 23:10 NRSV; כִּי בִּחְנֵנִי כִּזְהָב אֵצִי)

The verse falls at a moment of Job's deepest longing—his longing to find God, to lay his case before him, to be answered (23:3–7). In just that context of yearning and complaint, Job utters a declaration that seems to run against the grain of his present experience: "when he has tested me, I shall come out like gold." The metallurgical image—suffering figured as the refining of metal—is neither self-evident in Job's immediate situation nor a fact the narrative has yet delivered. It is an instinct that surfaces under extreme pressure. The very presence of that instinct is the central finding of this study: Job's text harbors, at this point, a teleological intuition, even though the intuition remains open and unresolved within the apophatic theodicy that governs the book as a whole. It is, moreover, Job's own hope, voiced in the midst of protest; the narrator nowhere endorses it, and the theophany conspicuously withholds the very confirmation it seems to anticipate. A caution about the philology is also in order. The refining force of the image is carried less by the verb *bāḥan* (בִּחַן)—a general term for testing or examining—than by the simile "like gold" (כִּזְהָב), which recruits the verb into a metallurgical register; *bāḥan* is not itself the technical vocabulary of the smelter.⁹

The image, in any case, does not stand alone. The refining of metal as a figure for divine testing is a settled topos of the Hebrew Bible: "The crucible is for silver, and the furnace is for gold, but the LORD tests the heart" (Prov 17:3); the LORD "will sit as a refiner and purifier of

⁹ On the semantic range of *bāḥan* (בִּחַן), a general verb of testing or examining (cf. Ps 7:10; Jer 17:10), see Ludwig Koehler and Walter Baumgartner, *The Hebrew and Aramaic Lexicon of the Old Testament* (Leiden: Brill, 1994–2000), s.v. The technical verbs for smelting and refining metal are rather *sārap* (צָרַפ) and *zāqaq* (זָקַק); the assaying connotation in Job 23:10 is supplied contextually by the simile "like gold," not by the verb itself.

silver" (Mal 3:3); "I will refine them as one refines silver, and test them as gold is tested" (Zech 13:9); "you have tried us as silver is tried" (Ps 66:10). Against this background Job 23:10 is not an isolated metaphor but a particular inflection of a shared scriptural grammar in which adversity assays and purifies what is already present. What distinguishes the Joban instance is its setting: the topos is voiced not as settled doctrine but from inside unresolved suffering, as the sufferer's own hope rather than the narrator's assurance.

3.4 The Opacity of the Theophany and Job's Transformation

The whirlwind theophany (38:1–42:6) is the theological summit of the book, and its meaning remains contested to this day—a contestation that is itself theologically significant. Newsom reads the theophany as an experience organized around wonder: the divine interrogation, opening "Where were you when I laid the foundation of the earth?" (38:4), reorients Job's attention through the overwhelming sensory amplitude of creation rather than through any moral or doctrinal instruction, and so subverts the very frame of his complaint instead of rebutting it in court.¹⁰ Clines, by contrast, is more inclined to hear the speeches as a coercive rhetoric: God presses Job with the crushing weight of cosmic knowledge and so answers, in effect, with power rather than with justice.¹¹ I do not think this interpretive tension—is the theophany an invitation to wonder or a silencing show of force?—is a difficulty to be dissolved. It is part of Joban theodicy. The opacity is not a problem to be cleared away but a theological statement to be received: the divine response to suffering cannot be systematized into a transparent teleology, and necessarily retains an irreducible dimension of mystery.

¹⁰ Carol A. Newsom, *The Book of Job: A Contest of Moral Imaginations* (New York: Oxford University Press, 2003), 236–37.

¹¹ David J. A. Clines, *Job 38–42*, WBC 18B (Nashville: Thomas Nelson, 2011), ad loc., reads the divine speeches as an exercise of overwhelming power rather than of justice.

Job's confession—"I have uttered what I did not understand, things too wonderful for me, which I did not know" (42:3)—is not a capitulation but the epistemic humility won before a divine knowledge that exceeds him. And his role after the theophany repays attention. YHWH directs the three friends to bring their sacrifices to Job, "and my servant Job shall pray for you, for I will accept his prayer not to deal with you according to your folly" (42:8). Job is not condemned; he is given the standing of an intercessor. What he has gained is not an increase of knowledge but a transformation of character—from plaintiff to intercessor. Integrity (*tummâ*, תָּמַךְ), in the ordeal, is not merely vindicated but deepened. What Job undergoes is a maturation that does not depend on having been given an explanation.

4. Mengzi 6B15: The Pedagogy of Heaven

4.1 The Textual Context of 6B15

Sections thirteen through sixteen of "Gaozi II" form a coherent sequence of argument concerned with adversity and moral growth. Across these passages Mengzi treats the conduct of one slighted by others (6B13), the steadfastness of the resolute (6B14), and Cao Jiao's question whether anyone can become a Yu or a King Wen (6B16). Within this cluster, 6B15 states the core theory in an almost declarative register, and supplies the theological foundation for the whole. It bears noting that the entire "Gaozi" group takes its name from Mengzi's debate with Gaozi over human nature (*xing* 性); the account in 6B15 of how Heaven forms its agents presupposes, and is best read against, that larger argument over what in human nature is given and what must be cultivated.¹²

¹² Note, too, that 6B15 sits within the "Gaozi" chapters, whose framing debate concerns human nature (*xing* 性). On the Mencian arguments about *xing*, see Irene Bloom, "Mencian Arguments on Human Nature (Jen-hsing)," *Philosophy East and West* 44, no. 1 (1994): 19–53; for the classical commentarial reading, see Zhu Xi, *Sishu zhangju jizhu* 四書章句集注 (Beijing: Zhonghua shuju, 1983).

In 6B15 Mengzi lists six historical figures as evidence that Heaven shapes its sages through adversity: Shun (舜) arose from the fields; Fu Yue (傅說) was raised up from amid the building of walls; Jiao Ge (膠鬲) from amid fish and salt; Guan Yiwu (管夷吾, i.e., Guan Zhong) from the hands of his jailer; Sunshu Ao (孫叔敖) from the seacoast; and Boli Xi (百里奚) from the marketplace.¹³ What the six share is that each was summoned out of the lowest or most straitened of circumstances, and each had been fitted for the burden of great office by a prior schooling in hardship. The historical evidence is not a string of fortunate exceptions but, for Mengzi, a cosmic regularity: Heaven deliberately tempers, through adversity, those it means to charge with weighty responsibility.

4.2 The Three Dimensions and the Concept of *Duan*

The central pronouncement of 6B15 distributes the pedagogical work of suffering across three interlocking dimensions. The canonical lines run:

"When Heaven is about to confer a great responsibility (*da ren*, 大任) on a person, it first makes their heart and mind suffer, toils their sinews and bones, starves their body, leaves them resourceless, and frustrates their undertakings—so as to stir their heart and mind, to steel their nature, and to supply what they had been unable to do." (*Mengzi* 6B15)

The three dimensions—the trial of will (*ku qi xin zhi*, 苦其心志), the testing of body and material circumstance (*lao qi jin gu*, 勞其筋骨), and the thwarting of one's plans of action (*xing fu luan*, 行拂亂其所為)—converge on a single end: to "stir the heart and steel the nature" (*dong xin ren xing*, 動心忍性), rousing inner moral strength and supplying the capacities not yet fully formed. Adversity here is not an incidental wound but a curriculum Heaven has designed.

¹³ Bryan W. Van Norden, trans., *Mengzi: With Selections from Traditional Commentaries* (Indianapolis: Hackett, 2008), 162 (*Mengzi* 6B15). Passages of the *Mengzi* displayed as block quotations are my own renderings, prepared in consultation with Van Norden; shorter in-text quotations likewise follow my rendering unless attributed otherwise. Classical Chinese is cited throughout in traditional characters, with romanization in pinyin.

Mengzi's pedagogy of adversity presupposes a particular account of human nature: that the nature carries innate moral tendencies, which Mengzi calls the "sprouts" (*duan*, 端). In "Gongsun Chou I" he distinguishes the sprouts of four virtues—the heart of compassion (the sprout of benevolence, *ren* 仁), the heart of shame (the sprout of righteousness, *yi* 義), the heart of deference (the sprout of propriety, *li* 禮), and the heart of approving and disapproving (the sprout of wisdom, *zhi* 智). A. C. Graham observes that the *duan* presuppose an organic theory of moral development: the sprouts of virtue are interior to human nature, and the function of external conditions—adversity included—is to create the environment in which the sprouts can grow, not to supply the sprout itself.¹⁴ This is decisive for the present argument. The *duan* are a prior potential that suffering refines rather than creates—and this is exactly where the structural parallel with the *tummâ* (תּוֹמָא) of Job lies, which is the heart of this study's cross-textual reading.

Ivanhoe makes the complementary point about moral psychology: what Mengzi envisions is an integrated psyche in which cognitive capacity, affective response, volitional strength, and a spiritual dimension are fused, and adversity is just the pressure that consolidates these dimensions into a coherent moral self.¹⁵ Unlike Job, who faces an insoluble divine riddle, Mengzi presents suffering as the path by which a person is developed into a leader of virtue, prepared to bear great responsibility (*da ren*, 大任).

4.3 The Functional Intentionality of Heaven

Mengzi's understanding of *tian* (天) is the most delicate matter in this study. In his systematic treatment, Kwong-loi Shun argues that the *tian* of the *Mengzi* exhibits a functional intentionality

¹⁴ A. C. Graham, *Disputers of the Tao: Philosophical Argument in Ancient China* (La Salle, IL: Open Court, 1989), 116–32, on the organic logic of the *duan* (端).

¹⁵ Philip J. Ivanhoe, *Ethics in the Confucian Tradition: The Thought of Mengzi and Wang Yangming*, 2nd ed. (Indianapolis: Hackett, 2002), 89.

—its operation displays purposiveness without necessarily presupposing a personal divine agent endowed with will.¹⁶ This stands in sharp contrast to the personal YHWH of Job, who may be petitioned and engaged in dialogue.

The textual ground for this reading—and the reason the status of *tian* remains contested—lies in passages such as *Mengzi* 5A5–6. There Mengzi denies that Yao could simply hand the empire to Shun and insists instead that "Heaven gave it to him"; pressed on how, he answers that "Heaven does not speak—it shows by deeds and affairs," and that what comes about though no one brings it about is the work of Heaven.¹⁷ The passage holds together two things that later readers have found hard to keep in balance. On one side, Heaven has a determinate will: it confers, withholds, and decrees. On the other, it exercises that will through the unforced course of events and the people's acceptance rather than through speech or visible intervention. This is why the reading of *tian* is genuinely disputed—some construe it as a quasi-personal moral agent, others as a naturalistic name for the way things fall out—and the dispute is not idle. But the argument here requires only the functional core that 5A5–6 secures: that Heaven's shaping of a person through hardship displays purpose, whether or not one is prepared to ascribe to it a personal will of the kind Job addresses.

Yet the contrast does not make Mengzi's Heaven simply impersonal. A substantive relation binds *tian* and the human heart-mind: "To fully fathom one's heart is to understand one's nature; to understand one's nature is to understand Heaven" (*Mengzi* 7A1).¹⁸ The direction of the logic is crucial. It does not descend from a knowledge of Heaven to an understanding of human nature; it ascends from the full realization of the nature within to a knowledge of Heaven. The

¹⁶ Kwong-loi Shun, *Mencius and Early Chinese Thought* (Stanford: Stanford University Press, 1997), 58–79, on the semantic range of *tian* and its non-anthropomorphic operation.

¹⁷ *Mengzi* 5A5–6, in Van Norden, *Mengzi*. On the manifestation of Heaven's will through deeds and affairs (行與事) rather than through speech, and the consequent difficulty of fixing the status of *tian*, see Shun, *Mencius and Early Chinese Thought*, 58–79.

¹⁸ Van Norden, *Mengzi*, 170 (*Mengzi* 7A1).

vector discloses the immanence of Mengzi's moral cosmos—Heaven is known not by external revelation but in the moral realization of human nature itself. This runs in the opposite direction from Job's epistemic path, which arrives at its transformation through the overwhelming, external event of the theophany.

5. A Mencian Reading of Job 23:10

Job 23:10 is the focal text of this cross-textual reading, because its metallurgical image, set within the frame of *Mengzi* 6B15, brings to the surface a teleological instinct in the Joban narrative that the philosophical frames most familiar in the West are not well equipped to describe. In the Western history of interpretation the verse has provoked sustained disagreement about its theological force. Newsom characterizes it as an "anomalous hope" within Job's larger framework of theological despair: in his present circumstances, his confidence that God will finally prove just lacks any secure epistemic footing, and reads less like grounded assurance than like a stubborn holding-on at the edge of an epistemological crisis.¹⁹ Habel reads more positively, taking it as a "bold trust"—Job, in a near-prophetic declaration, affirms his tenacious faith that God is ultimately just, however baffling God's present conduct.²⁰ Clines, for his part, hears an irony: Job turns God's own purposes against God's consistency—if God really is the assayer and refiner, why does he evade the very encounter the one being refined seeks?

Each reading has textual warrant, and each shares a single limitation: all three seek meaning strictly within the internal logic of the Joban text, without introducing an external term of comparison capable of letting the text's teleological dimension surface in a different way. Read through the lens of *Mengzi* 6B15, Job 23:10 takes on another aspect.

¹⁹ Newsom, *Book of Job*, 151–52.

²⁰ Habel, *Book of Job*, 339.

Mengzi construes adversity as Heaven's process of refining moral character, and his imagery is, precisely, metallurgical in spirit: an external power does not fabricate a new character but, through refining, burns off the dross and lets the essential substance show in its purity. The verb *bāhan* (𠬞𠬞, to assay) and the figure of gold in Job 23:10 are, within a Mencian frame, no longer merely a rhetorical flourish but an ontological description of how suffering works: suffering is a refiner, not a fabricator.

The Mencian reading discloses a two-tier teleological structure in Job 23:10. The first tier is divine initiative—"when he has tested me"—which marks the suffering not as a random cosmic accident but as the concrete execution of a refining intent. The second tier is the passive emergence of character—"I shall come out like gold"—which marks the gold (Job's *tummâ*, his integrity) as a potential already present in Job's character, and not something the suffering has fashioned out of nothing.

At this point the structural parallel between *tummâ* (integrity, 𠬞𠬞) and *duan* (the moral sprouts, 端) becomes visible. Both are qualities that suffering refines rather than creates; both presuppose a prior integrity in the moral agent and refuse to treat the agent as a blank slate; and both disclose their true nature fully only under adversity—*tummâ* proved under the sustained pressure of the friends, *duan* developed under hardship into completed virtue. This structural parallel is the central original contribution of the study. It does not assert that the two concepts are identical; it discloses a deep functional isomorphism—in both traditions suffering is the assaying agent that brings out a latent moral potential, not a machine that manufactures character.

The parallel must, however, be drawn with a precision the comparison itself demands, for the two terms are not symmetrical, and the asymmetry is instructive. *Tummâ* names a wholeness

Job already possesses—he is "blameless and upright" before the test (1:1)—so that suffering *proves* and displays his integrity rather than adding to it. The *duan*, by Mengzi's own botanical figure, are precisely incomplete: adversity *develops* them, ripening what is merely incipient into formed virtue. To prove a finished integrity and to grow an unfinished sprout are not the same operation, and I do not wish to smooth the difference away. The isomorphism I am claiming lies beneath it: in both cases the moral quality is a prior endowment latent in the agent, and suffering is the medium that brings it into its own—whether by assaying what is already whole or by maturing what is still in bud. It is this shared grammar—latency refined by adversity—rather than an identity of mechanism, that the cross-textual reading discloses; and naming the seam, far from weakening the parallel, is what keeps it honest.

A second and weightier disanalogy must be met head-on, since left unaddressed it would make the parallel either false or trivial. In *Mengzi* 6B15 the hardship is instrumental: Heaven afflicts the future minister in order to fit him for the "great responsibility" (*da ren*, 大任) of office, so that the suffering is calibrated to a downstream public role and is, in that sense, a means to an end Heaven intends. Job's ruin is not instrumental in this way. Nothing in the prologue presents his losses as preparation for an office he is about to assume; the heavenly wager (1:6–12) turns on whether his integrity is disinterested, not on whether he is being trained for a task. Were the *tummâ/duan* parallel pitched at the level of outcome—both sufferers emerging equipped for a role—it would simply be false of Job. I therefore locate the isomorphism not at the level of outcome but at the level of mechanism: in both texts adversity operates on a moral endowment already latent in the agent, drawing it out rather than implanting it, whether or not that operation is ordered to any further end. What the two share is the refining logic—prior latency disclosed and consolidated under pressure; what they need not share, and in

Job's case demonstrably do not, is the teleological destination toward which Mengzi's Heaven directs the process. Bracketing outcome in this way is not a retreat to safety but the very thing that keeps the comparison from collapsing into the truism that adversity builds character—a truism this argument must actively exclude if it is to say anything at all.

It is worth marking precisely what the claim thereby leaves out. It is not the Stoic thesis that hardship trains the soul toward an invulnerable equanimity (*apatheia*), for there the end is the extinction of disturbance, not the disclosure of a latent moral substance. It is not the Pauline sequence in which "suffering produces endurance, and endurance produces character" (Rom 5:3–4), for there the chain forges a new disposition along the way rather than assaying one already present. And it is not the athletic commonplace in which exertion simply builds a capacity that was not there before. The *tummâ/duan* isomorphism is the narrower and more determinate claim that suffering functions as the assayer of a moral endowment the agent already bears—and it is that specific mechanism, not the generic dignifying of hardship, that the cross-textual reading brings to light.

The Greco-Roman philosophical frames most often brought to the verse are, in their several ways, ill-suited to articulate just this reading of Job 23:10. Stoic *apatheia* construes suffering as a disturbance of the passions to be transcended by reason, and leaves no room for the ontological claim that suffering refines character.²¹ The hardest case here is Seneca, whose treatise on providence frames hardship as the training and the proof of the good man, and so approaches the Mencian intuition more nearly than Stoic *apatheia* alone would suggest; yet even there the end in view is the sage's rational invulnerability, not the refinement of a latent moral endowment into formed virtue. Platonic purification understands suffering as a means of

²¹ The hardest Stoic case is Seneca, *De Providentia*, in *Moral Essays*, vol. 1, trans. John W. Basore, Loeb Classical Library (Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press, 1928), where adversity is presented as the training and the proof of the good man.

releasing the soul from the bonds of matter, its goal being escape from the material realm in which suffering occurs rather than the development of character within it. And the Leibnizian optimism of the best possible world rationalizes suffering as a component of the overall optimal arrangement of the cosmos, attending to the macro-logic of the whole rather than to the inner mechanism by which an individual character is transformed in suffering.

Mengzi's frame thus offers a more interpretively powerful coordinate system for Job 23:10: it lets the teleological instinct that surfaces in Job's suffering—suffering as refinement, not punishment; character as disclosed, not created—achieve conceptual articulation. And yet this Mencian reading must be kept within the larger opacity of Joban theology. The teleological instinct of Job 23:10 surfaces against the unlit background of the theophany; it cannot be converted, without remainder, into the transparent, systematizable teleology of Mengzi. That very reservation is the method enacting itself: juxtaposition, not synthesis; illumination, not equivalence.

6. Convergences

For all the distance between their cultural worlds, Job and Mengzi share four core convictions about suffering and moral formation.

First, both challenge a simplified moral causality. Job refuses the friends' assumption that suffering must issue from sin; Mengzi criticizes those who instrumentalize virtue in the pursuit of external reward, holding that the noble person (*junzi*, 君子) keeps to righteousness (*yi*, 義) in any material circumstance and does not let material outcome be the measure of moral action. YHWH's rebuke of Job's friends (42:7) and Mengzi's rebuke of King Hui of Liang, who opens

by asking after profit—"Why must Your Majesty speak of profit?" (*Mengzi* 1A1)—²²both register a shared resistance to utilitarian moral calculation.

Second, both texts situate human moral development within a cosmic structure, lending suffering a significance that exceeds the merely individual or psychological. Job's theophany locates human ethical existence against the vast backdrop of divine creation and sovereignty (chs. 38–41); *Mengzi* binds human virtue to the will of Heaven (7A1, "to understand one's nature is to understand Heaven"). Both decline to reduce the problem of suffering to private psychology or social circumstance, grounding the moral meaning of suffering instead within the order of the cosmos.

Third, both resist what may be called a prosperity theology—the disposition to seek righteousness chiefly for the sake of material blessing. Job's narrative displays a man blameless by every available measure who nonetheless undergoes extreme suffering (the contrast between 1:1–3 and 1:13–19), and so overturns the tidy equation that the righteous must be blessed. *Mengzi*, through his six exemplars—every one of whom passed through material hardship and social lowliness—demonstrates from the other side that material adversity is the ordinary road by which great moral leaders are formed, not the exception to it.

The epilogue, in which Job's fortunes are not merely restored but doubled (42:10–17), might seem to reinstate the very equation the book has dismantled—virtue rewarded with wealth after all. But the restoration will not bear that weight. Job is vindicated before he is restored, and on grounds that have nothing to do with reward: YHWH declares that Job has spoken of him "what is right" (42:7) while the friends have not, and the turn in his fortunes follows his intercession for those friends (42:10), not any repentance that purchases relief. The doubling, moreover, is gratuitous rather than calibrated—an overflow that exceeds any ledger of desert

²² Van Norden, *Mengzi*, 2 (*Mengzi* 1A1).

rather than a payment that settles one. Read this way, the epilogue does not resurrect the retributive scheme; it stages a divine generosity that operates outside the economy of merit the friends had assumed. Mengzi makes the complementary point from the other direction: that several of his exemplars rose, in the end, to high office is incidental to the claim, for the formation Heaven intends is accomplished in the tempering itself, whatever its outward issue.

Fourth, both make the active holding-fast of moral character under adversity the central path to moral maturity. Job's persistence in his integrity (*tummâ*, תָּמַךְ) under the friends' relentless assault is itself the mark of a maturing character; Mengzi's "stirring the heart and steeling the nature" describes not passive endurance but an active rousing and strengthening of latent moral capacity under hardship. Both demand that the moral agent retain agency in suffering, rather than merely submit to it or flee it.

7. Divergences

Four divergences, by contrast, are fundamental and irreducible. They are not to be reconciled but to be preserved within a hermeneutical tension—and it is precisely that tension that makes the two traditions mutually illuminating.

The first concerns the nature of the cosmic power: the personal YHWH set against a functional Heaven. The God of Job is a personal being who can be addressed in the idiom of the lawcourt—Job casts his suffering in juridical metaphor, seeks a "mediator," and longs to plead his case before God (9:32–35; 16:19–21; 19:25–27). This juridical, relational conception of the divine lets Job engage God as an interlocutor rather than a mere creature. Mengzi's Heaven has no such relational structure: the bond between the human and Heaven is forged not through petition and reply but through the full realization of interior virtue. The difference is ontological,

not merely theological: Job's suffering is defined within a rupture of relationship, whereas the suffering Mengzi treats is a functional context of development.

The second concerns the path of knowledge: revelation against cultivation. Job's epistemic transformation comes through the theophany, an overwhelming revelation that breaks in from outside (38:1); Mengzi's moral epistemology grows from within, through introspection and cultivation ("to fully fathom one's heart is to understand Heaven," 7A1). Job's frame presupposes that genuine knowledge comes from divine self-disclosure, exceeding independent human cognition; Mengzi's frame presupposes that genuine moral knowledge already lies latent in human nature, and that cultivation activates it rather than waiting upon an external revelation. As Seow observes, Job, unlike the friends who appeal to the double authority of tradition and community, gives priority to personal experience.²³ That individualized, finally mystical mode of disclosure stands in sharp relief against Mengzi's more publicly legible moral cosmos, in which the workings of Heaven can be known and deliberately participated in.

The third concerns the transparency of teleology. Mengzi's teleology of suffering is transparent: Heaven forms moral leaders through adversity, and the mechanism, the goal, and the evidence of that process can all be stated plainly and generalized from historical cases. Job's teleology of suffering is apophatic: what Job gains in suffering is not an explanation of its purpose but, in the theophany, a recognition of the limits of his own cognition—"things too wonderful for me, which I did not know" (42:3). The contrast between this negative theodicy and Mengzi's positive teleology is among the deepest divergences of the two traditions.

The fourth concerns the irreducible mystery of the theophany as itself a theological statement. The whirlwind theophany is not merely the narrative climax of Job; it is the

²³ Choon-Leong Seow, *Job 1–21: Interpretation and Commentary*, Illuminations (Grand Rapids: Eerdmans, 2013), 97.

embodiment of a theological stance. God's response to the problem of suffering structurally refuses the direct teleological answer ("this is for the sake of X"), substituting instead the overwhelming experience of creation's mystery. That refusal is part of the theological content: the ultimate meaning of suffering is held open, closed off by no human framework—not even Mengzi's teleological one. The teleological instinct that a Mencian reading of Job 23:10 discloses must therefore be preserved within the overall opacity of Joban theology, and not converted into a transparent Mencian teleology. This irreducible difference is exactly the ground on which the two traditions check each other, and together gesture toward a richer theodicy.

8. Contributions to Theodicy: A Productive Tension

The cross-textual juxtaposition of the two texts makes three specific contributions to contemporary theodical discourse—and it makes them precisely by preserving the tension between the two rather than by engineering a synthesis.

First, Job restrains the Mencian tendency toward over-systematization. The strength of Mengzi's account of Heaven's formation of moral leaders through adversity lies in its lucid teleology: suffering has a purpose, that purpose can be known, and it can even be generalized from historical cases. But that very lucidity is also the latent weakness of his theodicy. Confronted with suffering of the Joban kind—the complete ruin of an innocent, devoid of any discernible pedagogical purpose—the Mencian frame is liable to slide toward rationalizing all suffering whatsoever, and so to foreclose genuine protest against it. By presenting suffering as operating on a cosmic plane (the heavenly prologue, 1:6–12) and as exceeding the reach of human explanation, Job supplies the counterweight that Mencian systematization requires.

Second, Mengzi keeps the Joban narrative from sliding into nihilism. At the depth of its existential crisis, Job's narrative faces the threat of a total loss of meaning: if suffering can be

explained within no framework of moral causality, and if the divine response only answers mystery with mystery, does Job's story finally disclose a morally meaningless cosmos? Here Mengzi supplies a useful counter-force: suffering can indeed have a teleological structure, adversity can indeed refine rather than destroy, and the functional intentionality of Heaven offers a framework within which the meaning of suffering is grounded. Mengzi's contribution is not to impose that framework directly on Job, but to furnish a conceptual resource by which the teleological instinct that surfaces in Job 23:10 can be taken seriously as theology rather than dismissed as the groundless cry of a man in extremity.

Third, the comparison brings to light a dimension that Western theodical frames have tended to leave under-described. Surin warns that systematic theodicies—whether Leibnizian optimism, soul-making theodicy, or the finite God of process theology—court the danger of reducing real suffering to a conceptual exercise.²⁴ The cross-cultural hermeneutic adopted here keeps theodical discourse open precisely by refusing the closure of any single system: Job's apophatic tension and Mengzi's teleological clarity hold each other in check, yielding a theodical stance that is more honest, more complex, and more answerable to the actual experience of suffering. This stance is also pointedly distinct from comparative approaches that adjudicate suffering through an imported third framework—an Aristotelian account of the virtues, say—whose categories neither tradition generates from within. By letting the two traditions converse within their own logics, the present reading discloses each tradition's own native response to suffering—and the productive tension their juxtaposition generates—rather than a shared conclusion underwritten by an external framework.²⁵

²⁴ Kenneth Surin, *Theology and the Problem of Evil* (Oxford: Blackwell, 1986), 1–59. Surin's warning against "theoretical" theodicies that dissolve concrete suffering into abstraction informs the argument throughout.

²⁵ R. S. Sugirtharajah, *The Bible and the Third World: Precolonial, Colonial, and Postcolonial Encounters* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2001), 246–48.

The practical import of this productive tension is that it offers the sufferer two complementary resources rather than two competing systems. Mengzi's frame licenses the active search for meaning in adversity, the recognition that suffering may be a process of formation rather than mere punishment or random misfortune; Job's frame licenses honest protest and a candid facing of divine mystery, refusing to cheapen real pain with imposed meaning. Consider a person facing a grave and undeserved illness. The Mencian frame invites a question that can console without dishonesty: what capacity might this ordeal be forming—patience, depth, fellow-feeling with others who suffer—even where no cosmic ledger guarantees the result? The Joban frame, at the same moment, authorizes the protest that the Mencian question, pressed too hard, would silence: the refusal to call the affliction good, the insistence that the sufferer may demand an answer and receive, instead, the unmastered presence of God. Held together, the two let the sufferer seek formation without lapsing into the friends' tidy accounting, and protest without concluding that the suffering means nothing at all. Together they furnish a theodical posture more honest, more complex, and more answerable to lived suffering than any single system on its own.

9. Conclusion

Reading the book of Job alongside the fifteenth section of "Gaozi II," I have argued that the two texts stand in a productive tension—one that can neither be synthesized into a single theodical system nor, on account of its differences, dismissed as incapable of dialogue. The methodological viability of cross-textual hermeneutics is borne out in the comparison: it lets difference speak in juxtaposition, without forcing the two traditions toward a preordained reconciliation.

The central original contribution of the study is this: taking Job 23:10 ("when he has tested me, I shall come out like gold"; כִּי בִּחְנֹנִי כִּזְהָב אֵצִא) as the demonstration text, a Mencian reading discloses a teleological instinct in the Joban text that the philosophical frames most familiar in the West—Stoic, Platonic, Leibnizian—are not well equipped to describe. The structural parallel between *tummâ* (integrity, תְּמִימָה) and *duan* (the moral sprouts, 端)—both of them qualities that suffering refines rather than creates, both presupposing a prior potential in the moral agent—supplies a conceptual bridge of analytic precision rather than a loose analogy.

At the same time, I have insisted on the irreducible apophatic dimension of Joban theodicy. The mystery of the theophany, and the final openness of the meaning of Job's suffering, are the theological content of Joban theodicy, not its theological weakness. The juxtaposition of the two texts therefore yields not a solution to the problem of theodicy but a more honest tension: Mengzi discloses that suffering can have a teleological structure, and Job insists that this structure cannot be closed into a transparent system. Together they answer more adequately to the complexity of human suffering, and to its potential to be transformed into moral growth.

The study carries a broader methodological implication. Biblical scholarship gains from dialogue with non-Western traditions not because those traditions supply an exotic interpretive key, but because they expose dimensions internal to the original tradition that had been kept in shadow. The teleological instinct in Job is not conferred by Mengzi; rather, the Mencian frame lets a dimension already present in Job 23:10 come to light. This mutual illumination across cultures is among the most constructive contributions that comparative scripture and comparative theology can make.

For future work, three lines suggest themselves: a comparison of Job's role as intercessor (42:8–9) with the Confucian sage's responsibility for the world; an epistemological comparison of the *via negativa* of apophatic theodicy with the positive Confucian path of knowing Heaven through cultivation; and an extension of the inquiry to a wider range of Asian classical traditions on suffering—Buddhist and Daoist among them—in cross-textual conversation with the biblical text. The pairing of Job and Mengzi suggests that theodical discourse grows richer, more honest, and more capable of facing real suffering when it is illumined across cultures.

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